
SCITI 2026 Performance Audit

PR vs. Results: What Thailand's Smart City Program Actually Delivered

An independent assessment based on SLIC methodology, field verification, and public data

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Contents

1. Program Overview & Timeline
2. PR vs. Results Gap Analysis
3. Public Sentiment
4. ASEAN Comparison
5. Recommendations

1. Program Overview

37 certified (Batches 1-4). 168+ promotion zones. Fewer than 10 with operational smart infrastructure. 3 certified cities have zero permanent residents. Original 100-by-2022 target quietly abandoned. Current target: 105 by 2027.

Year	Event	Status
2017	depa established, Thailand 4.0	Positive
2018	Program launched, 7 domains, 100-city target	Positive
2019	Batch 1: 15 certified, Khon Kaen LRT announced	Positive
2020	COVID stalls physical projects	Neutral
2021	Batch 2, 100-by-2022 target abandoned	Negative
2022	Batch 3, IMD: Bangkok 68-80th globally	Negative
2023	Master Plan 2, academic criticism mounts	Negative
2024-25	Batch 4: only 1 new city, pipeline slowing	Negative
2026	SCITI launches — first outcome-based assessment	Positive

2. PR vs. Results Gap

Certification does not equal infrastructure. The Smart City Local logo is awarded based on plan approval, not deployment.

Domain	PR	Result	Gap
Smart Economy	85	42	Critical
Smart Mobility	90	35	Critical
Smart Energy	60	55	Low
Smart Governance	70	30	Critical
Smart Living	75	38	High
Smart People	55	25	Critical
Smart Environment	80	40	High
Smart Security	65	45	Medium

Smart Mobility (PR 90 vs Result 35): Khon Kaen LRT delayed 7+ years. Phuket bus covers 1 route. No city achieved mode shift.

Smart Governance (PR 70 vs Result 30): data.go.th low municipal adoption. Most cities still paper-based.

3. Public Sentiment

Segment	%	Voice
Supportive	22%	Industry insiders and officials

Unaware	31%	Most citizens never heard of it
Skeptical	33%	All talk, no action
Hostile	14%	Waste of taxpayer money

"They gave the logo to an empty field and called it #1. Then they wonder why nobody trusts the program." — Pantip, 2024

4. ASEAN Comparison

Country	Status	Assessment
Singapore	Global leader	Real systems, city-state advantage
Vietnam	Catching up	Da Nang success, ahead per dollar
Malaysia	Similar	Iskandar/Cyberjaya have real infra
Indonesia	Same issues	Jakarta real, most others plans
Thailand	Mixed	37 certified, <10 operational

5. Recommendations

[MORE] More implementation, less certification

Shift KPIs from cities certified to services delivered. Only 8 of 37 score Alpha.

[MORE] Financial clinics for municipalities

Most don't know how to structure PPP or access climate finance. Hands-on workshops.

[MORE] Activate international MOUs

Of 15 MOUs, only JICA and USTDA produced outcomes. Activate the rest.

[MORE] Outcome measurement + accountability

No public outcome tracking exists. Publish annual reports per certified city.

[LESS] Paperwork and certification overhead

12-18 months for a logo. Streamline to 3 months.

[LESS] Top-down, more bottom-up

NST and Saensuk started with citizen complaints, not national announcements.